CWL workflows with MPI in bare-metal, containers, cloud, and HPC

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Agenda

- Introduction
- Motivation
- Results
- Conclusion
- Future Work

Introduction

Introduction — MPI and CWL

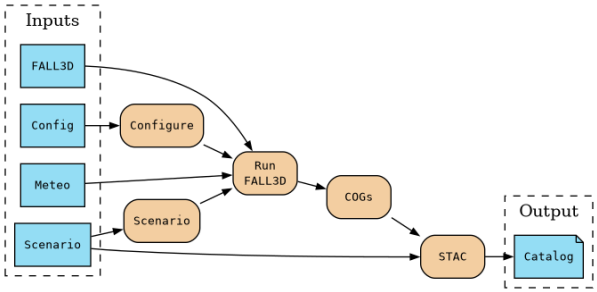


A **portable** message-passing **standard** for **parallel programming** widely used in HPC.



A **standard** for describing **computational workflows**, focused on **portability** and reproducibility across environments.

Introduction — Computational Workflows

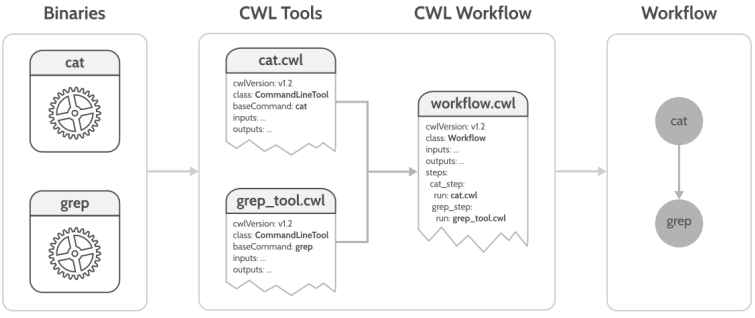


Source
GEO3BCN-CSIC
FALL3D Workflow

GET-IT workflows for Etna and La Palma test cases

https://gitlab.geo3bcn.csic.es/fall3d/getit-workflows

Introduction — Common Workflow Language (CWL)




```
Terminal                                    - + x
user@node> cwltool workflow.cwl
```

```
Terminal                                    - + x
user@node> cat poem.txt | grep "terra" > output.log
```

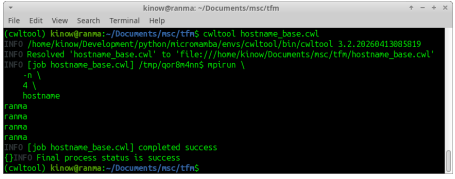
Introduction — MPIRequirement

```
$ cwltool hostname_base.cwl
```

```
# File: hostname_base.cwl
cwlVersion: v1.2
class: CommandLineTool

baseCommand: mpirun
arguments:
  - "-n"
  - "4"
  - "hostname"

inputs: []
outputs: []
```




```
$ cwltool --mpi-config-file mpi-config.yml \
    hostname_mpireq.cwl
```

```
# File: hostname_mpireq.cwl
cwlVersion: v1.2
class: CommandLineTool

requirements:
  - class: "cwltool:MPIRequirement"
    processes: 4

baseCommand: hostname

inputs: []
outputs: []
```

MPI configuration file

```
# File: mpi-config.yml
runner: srun
nproc_flag: "-n"
extra_flags: "--hostfile /shared/hostfile"
```

Motivation

Motivation

The portability of MPI-enabled workflows in CWL remains largely unvalidated.

The `MPIRequirement` extension (Nash et al., 2020) has not been systematically evaluated across CWL runners and execution environments.

Nash et al. (2020), WORKS 2020 (IEEE/ACM)
DOI: 10.1109/WORKS51914.2020.00008

Results

CWL Conformance Tests

Results — CWL Conformance Tests

cwltool

v	FT3		MN5		LUMI	
	l	s	l	s	l	s
1.0.2						
1.1.0						
1.2.1						

StreamFlow

v	FT3		MN5		LUMI	
	l	s	l	s	l	s
1.0.2						
1.1.0						
1.2.1						

Toil

v	FT3			MN5			LUMI		
	l	s	b	l	s	b	l	s	b
1.0.2									
1.1.0									
1.2.1									

≥ 95%
70–95%
< 70%
not run

l login-node
s slurm-node
b slurm-batch

Results — CWL Conformance Tests

StreamFlow

v	FT3		MN5		LUMI	
	l	s	l	s	l	s
1.0.2	∘	∘	∘	△∘		
1.1.0						
1.2.1			∘	△∘		

Toil

v	FT3			MN5			LUMI		
	l	s	b	l	s	b	l	s	b
1.0.2			□		△	△□			□
1.1.0			□		△	△□			□
1.2.1			□		△	△□			□

Observed Issues

- △ No network access
- ∘ Singularity container issues
- □ Slurm submission errors
- Symlink issues
- Race conditions
- Tests bootstrap problems in HPC
- Slurm compute node /tmp
- Intermittent failures

- 13 issues reported already

Simple MPI Workflow

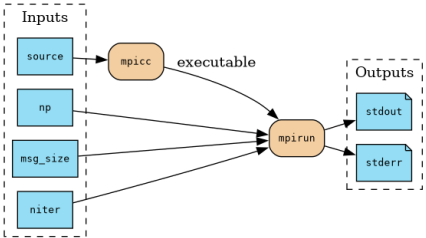
Results — Simple MPI Workflow

baseCommand: mpirun

Mode	Laptop	Cloud	MN5	LUMI
cwltool (n)				
cwltool (s)				
Toil (n)				
Toil (s)				

MPIRequirement

Mode	Laptop	Cloud	MN5	LUMI
cwltool (n)				
cwltool (s)				
Toil (n)				
Toil (s)				



OK
ERROR
INVALID*

(n) No container
(s) Singularity

* MPI launched through the container rather than the host launcher.

Results — Simple MPI Workflow

baseCommand: mpirun

Mode	Laptop	Cloud	MN5	LUMI
cwltool (n)				□
cwltool (s)			△	
Toil (n)			■	□
Toil (s)			△	

MPIRequirement

Mode	Laptop	Cloud	MN5	LUMI
cwltool (n)				
cwltool (s)	∘	∘	∘	∘
Toil (n)			■	
Toil (s)	∘	∘	∘	∘

Observed Issues

- △ No network access
- ∘ cwltool `MPIRequirement` bug
- □ No mpirun
- ■ No mpi.h
- `singularity mpirun...`
- 1 issue + 1 pull request in cwltool

OK
ERROR
INVALID*

(n) No container
(s) Singularity

* MPI launched through the container rather than the host launcher.

FALL3D Workflow

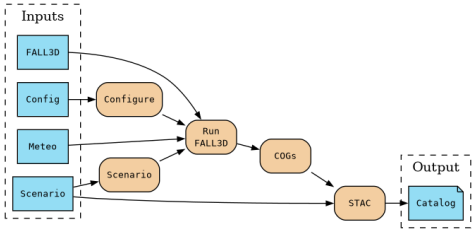
Results — FALL3D Workflow

baseCommand: mpirun

Mode	Laptop	Cloud	LUMI
cwltool (n)			
cwltool (s)			

MPIRequirement

Mode	Laptop	Cloud	LUMI
cwltool (n)			
cwltool (s)			



OK
ERROR
INVALID*

(n) No container
(s) Singularity

* MPI launched through the container rather than the host launcher.

Results — FALL3D Workflow

baseCommand: mpirun

Mode	Laptop	Cloud	LUMI
cwltool (n)	△		□
cwltool (s)		■	

MPIRequirement

Mode	Laptop	Cloud	LUMI
cwltool (n)			
cwltool (s)	○	○	○

Observed Issues

- △ ABI-compatibility issue
- □ no mpirun
- ■ MPI oversubscription
- ○ cwltool `MPIRequirement` bug
- `singularity mpirun...`
- 2 issues + 1 pull request in cwltool

OK
ERROR
INVALID*

(n) No container
(s) Singularity

* MPI launched through the container rather than the host launcher.

New Results!

New Results 09/26 — CWL Conformance Tests

cwltool

v	FT3		MN5		LUMI		Fugaku	
	l	s	l	s	l	s	l	p
1.0.2								
1.1.0								
1.2.1								

Toil

v	FT3			MN5			LUMI		
	l	s	b	l	s	b	l	s	b
1.0.2			□		△	△□			□
1.1.0			□		△	△□			□
1.2.1			□		△	△□			□

Observations

- △ No network access
- □ Slurm submission errors

- Toil passed all tests on CESGA FT3 !
- cwltool passed all tests on RIKEN Fugaku !

New Results 09/26 — Simple MPI Workflow / Fugaku

baseCommand: mpirun

Mode	Laptop	Cloud	MN5	LUMI	Fugaku
cwltool (n)				□	
cwltool (s)			△		▪

MPIRequirement

Mode	Laptop	Cloud	MN5	LUMI	Fugaku
cwltool (n)					
cwltool (s)	∘	∘	∘	∘	▪

Observations

- △ No network access
- □ No mpirun
- ∘ cwltool `MPIRequirement` bug
- ▪ aarch64 container issue
- `singularity mpirun...`

OK
ERROR
INVALID*

(n) No container
(s) Singularity

* MPI launched through the container rather than the host launcher.

Conclusion

Conclusion

- **`MPIRequirement` improves portability and execution success across heterogeneous environments.**
- CWL runners differ in HPC compatibility, especially for MPI and Slurm execution.
- Container and runtime integration issues still limit full portability in some HPC systems.
- A total of 33 (**now 40+**) issues related to CWL, MPI, & HPC reported to 12 OSS projects.

Future work

CWL & HPC & MPI

- Improve HPC scheduler integration (Slurm, PBS, LSF, Flux, **PJM**, ...) in CWL runners.
- Extend evaluation to more CWL runners and HPC systems and MPI implementations (e.g., **Fujitsu**).
- Inclusion of `MPIRequirement` in CWL standards and additional CWL runners (**and a paper**!).

Beyond MPI

- Support heterogeneous paradigms (MPI+X, OpenMP, CUDA, HIP, ...).

CoWORKER EuroHPC CoE, HPC and workflows

The European Centre of Excellence on Workflow Orchestration, Regularisation, Knowledge Enablement, and Retrospection

Authors: Iacopo Colonnelli, Marco Aldinucci, Gabriel Antoniu, Rosa M. Badia, Sara Bozzi, Silvina Caíno-Lores, Barbara Cantalupo, Michael R. Crusoe, Sagar Dolas, Rosa Filgueira, Daniele Gregori, Tim Kok, Jakob Lüttgau, Giuseppe Melfi, Raffaele Montella, Alberto Mulone, Silvana Muscella, Simone Rizzo, Roberto Rocco, Marco Edoardo Santimaria, Gabriella Scipione, Raül Sirvent, Giuseppe Trotta, Marius van den Beek and Marco Verdicchio



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The Centre of Excellence on Workflow Orchestration, Regularisation, Knowledge Enablement, and Retrospection (CoWORKER) is a European cross-disciplinary competence centre for large-scale scientific workflows that aims to improve the productivity, portability, and sustainability of complex HPC- and AI-enabled applications. By integrating technical services, co-design activities, training, and community-driven standards, CoWORKER will support the complete workflow lifecycle across heterogeneous computing environments, including HPC, cloud, AI, and quantum platforms. The initiative promotes interoperability, reproducibility, and open software ecosystems while strengthening European digital sovereignty. Through collaboration with the EuroHPC ecosystem and the broader scientific community, CoWORKER seeks to accelerate workflow adoption, software modernisation, and the long-term impact of workflow-based scientific applications.

Data Availability

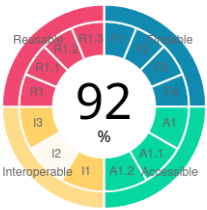
All experimental artefacts are publicly available.

`https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.20348637`

`https://github.com/kinow/cwl-mpi`

RO-Crate metadata included for reproducibility and reuse.

F-UJI score: 92%, Advanced.



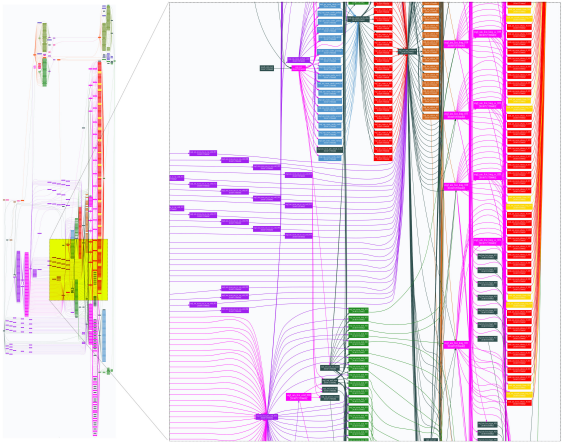
Questions?

Thank you.

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Introduction — Computational Workflows



Source
H. Oliver et al. (2019)
Workflow Automation for Cycling Systems

Unified Model (UM) example with Cylc.

Computing in Science & Engineering (IEEE)
DOI: 10.1109/MCSE.2019.2906593

Performance — MPI Bandwidth Comparison (`osu_bw`)

LUMI MPI point-to-point bandwidth benchmark (`pt2pt/osu_bw`, `--mpi=pmi2`).

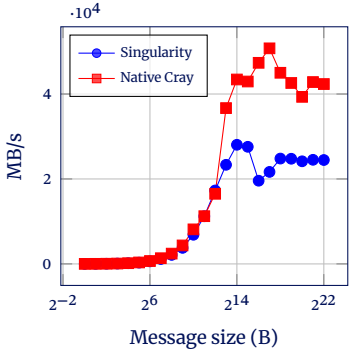
Singularity

Size	BW
1	10.25
2	20.01
8	81.94
32	299.38
128	1153.15
512	3777.49
2048	11220.21
8192	23334.12
16384	28045.90
65536	19587.88
131072	21663.76
524288	24758.18
2097152	24510.72
4194304	24461.10

Native Cray

Size	BW
1	8.53
2	21.18
8	86.06
32	344.33
128	1340.01
512	4353.42
2048	11235.76
8192	36684.87
16384	43421.54
65536	47344.88
131072	50755.53
524288	42599.48
2097152	42816.48
4194304	42347.43

Comparison



FALL3D — Output

